

# Group Formation & Topic Selection

PS50008A Week 16 | Lab Walkthrough

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# The Road Ahead

# Where We Are and Where We're Going

# Your Four Assessments

| Assessment             | Weight | Deadline                            | Status               |
|------------------------|--------|-------------------------------------|----------------------|
| <b>Research Plan</b>   | 20%    | Fri 27 Feb,<br>12 noon              | <b>Due tomorrow!</b> |
| <b>MCQ Exam</b>        | 20%    | Wed 11 Mar,<br>~1 hour (in lecture) | Week 18              |
| <b>EDS Assignment</b>  | 20%    | Fri 20 Mar,<br>12 noon (~1-2 hours) | Week 19              |
| <b>Research Report</b> | 40%    | Mid-late April 12                   | Post-Easter          |

# The Next 5 Weeks — What Happens When

| Week     | Lab Focus                                  | Milestone              |
|----------|--------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| 16 (now) | Group formation, topic selection           | Group registration     |
| 17       | Finalising methodology                     | Methodology agreed     |
| 18       | Finalising procedure, piloting with Gordon | Procedure complete     |
| 19       | Data collection                            | Data collected         |
| 20       | Write-up support                           | Report drafting begins |

## Assessments During This Period

- **MCQ Exam** — Wed 11 Mar (~1 hour, in lecture)
- **EDS Assignment** — paper released on Monday, due Fri 20 Mar, 12 noon (~1-2 hours)
- **Research Report** — Mid-late April, 12 noon



# Your Group Project Timeline

**The group project feeds directly into your Research Report (40%).**

You work together to design and run a study. Then each person writes their own individual report.

# What Your Group Does Together vs. Individually

## Together (Weeks 16–20)

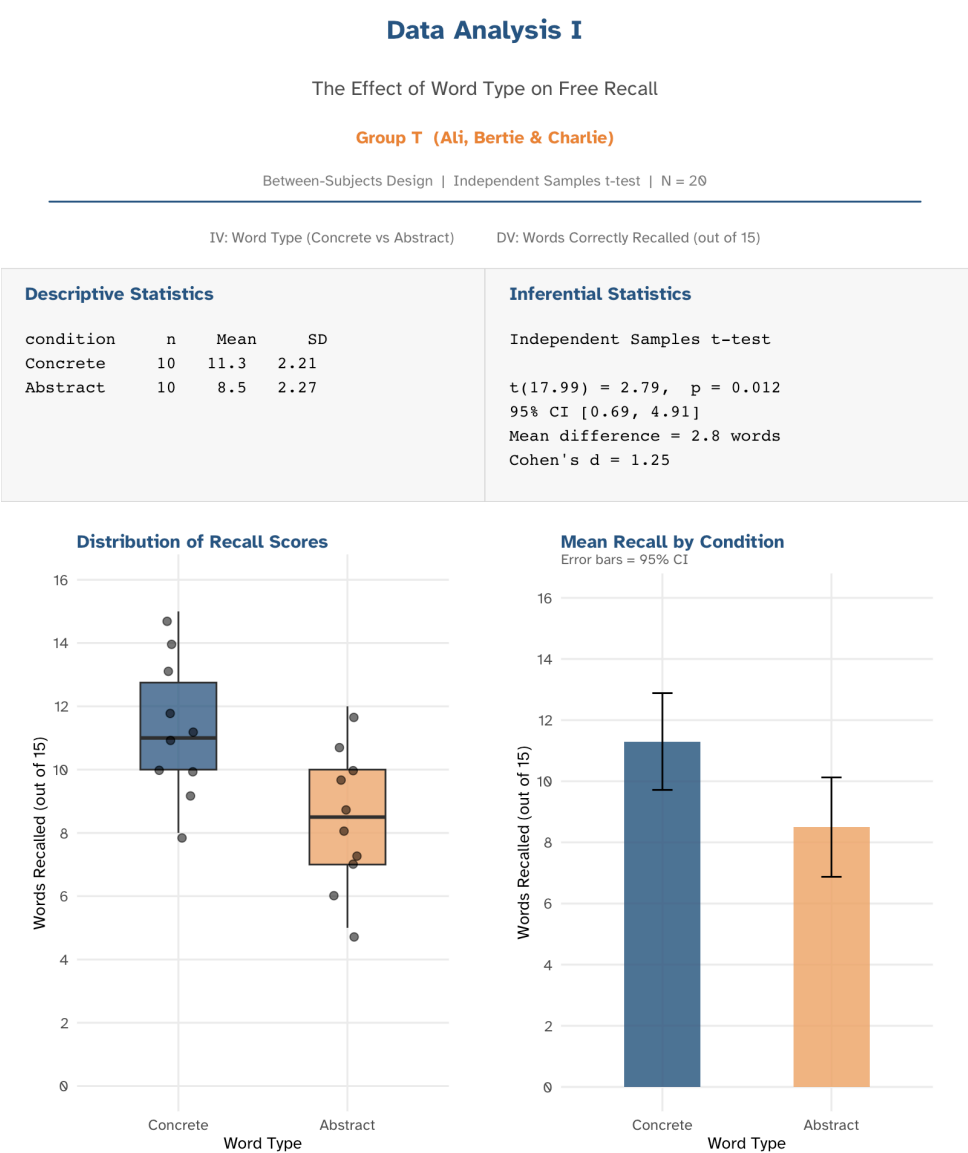
- Topic selection
- Literature review
- Design the study
- Create materials & procedure
- Collect data
- Review results

## Individually

- Write your own 2,500-word Research Report
- Same data, **different reports**
- Do NOT share written drafts
- Sharing text = academic misconduct

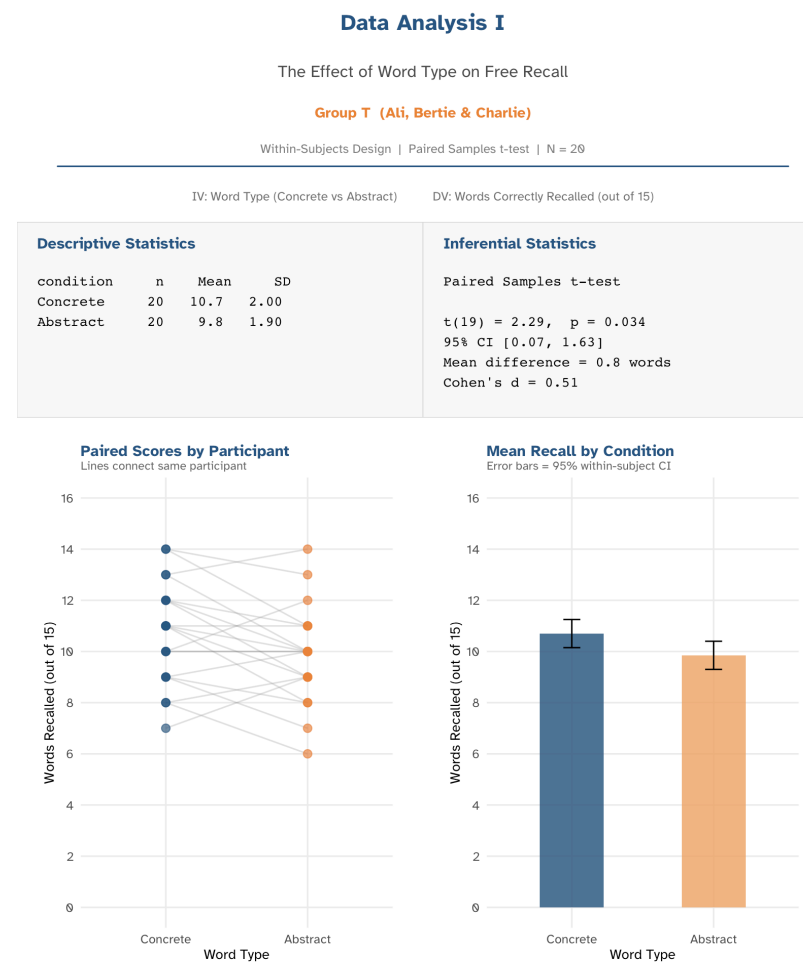
# What You'll Get Back: Data Analysis I — Between-Subjects

After your group collects data in **Week 19**, I'll run the analysis and return a one-page summary like this:





# What You'll Get Back: Data Analysis I — Within-Subjects



## Your Job

You don't need to run the analysis yourself — I provide the output. Your Research Report interprets and discusses these results.

# What You Need to Do This Week

**Today (Thursday):** Form your group, choose your topic, find a key paper

**Tomorrow (Friday 27 Feb, 12 noon):** Submit your Research Plan via Learn.Gold

**Next week onwards:** Work collaboratively to complete each week's milestones — see the projects documents on the VLE for more information.

 **OneDrive Group Folder**



# Today's Lab

# Group Formation & Topic Selection



# Today's Priorities

## Three things matter today:

1. **Form your group** (3–4 is ideal, but the key thing is you join one)
2. **Choose your project topic** — from the [example list](#) or create your own
3. **Find a key paper** — something to anchor your methodology or hypothesis

# Lab Structure (~90 min)

| Time            | Activity                                         |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 10:00–<br>10:15 | These slides + group formation                   |
| 10:15–<br>10:30 | Topic selection, identify variables              |
| 10:30–<br>11:00 | Literature searching (PsycINFO + Google Scholar) |
| 11:00–<br>11:30 | Evaluating sources + recording findings          |
| 11:30–          | Group discussion: hypothesis development         |





# Part 1: Group Formation

# Finding Your People (~15 min)

# Form Groups of 3–4

- Look around — find 2–3 people to work with
- You'll work together for the **rest of the term**
- Data collection, methodology, procedure — all done as a group
- The **Research Report is individual** — you share data, not words



## Group Allocation

Students not part of a registered group this week will be **allocated to a group on Monday of Week 17.**

# Register Your Group

## Group Registration Form

Register your group here

Enter your group members and any preliminary topic ideas.

### **Also do these now:**

1. Exchange contact details (email / phone / WhatsApp)
2. Set up a group chat
3. Agree on how you're going to work together
4. Familiarise yourself with the weekly milestones

# How Group Work → Individual Report

**Together:** Design study → Collect data → Share raw data

**Individually:** Write your own 2,000-word Research Report

Same data, different reports. Do NOT share written drafts.





# Part 2: Topic Selection

# Choosing What You'll Investigate (~15 min)



# Choosing Your Topic

Each group needs a project topic. You can:

- **Choose from the 9 example topics** — fully scoped, ready to go
- **Adapt an example** — modify it slightly to suit your interests
- **Propose your own** — as long as it meets the key requirement below

## ! Key Requirement

Your topic must be testable using a **two-group t-test** (between-subjects or within-subjects). Think small-scale: ~15–20 participants, short tasks (~5–10 min per

# Identify Your Variables

**As a group, confirm:**

- What is the **independent variable**? How many levels?
- What is the **dependent variable**? How is it measured?
- What **design** are you using? Between or within?

If you're unsure about any of these, ask your tutor now.



# Part 3: Literature Searching

# Finding Relevant Research (~30 min)



# Starting Points

I've included some starting-point papers on Learn for each example topic:

[Papers folder on Learn](#) — a couple of papers per topic

They're not all perfect — a quick literature search may turn up something more relevant, more recent, or a better methodological match. Use them as a springboard.

## More Resources

- [Template documents on Learn](#) — with worked examples
- [Project Toolkit](#) — overview of each project

# Where to Search

## **PsycINFO** (via Goldsmiths Library)

- Psychology-specific, peer-reviewed
- Best for targeted research

## **Google Scholar** ([scholar.google.com](https://scholar.google.com))

- Broader coverage, citation tracking
- Set up Goldsmiths Library Links for full-text access

# Search Strategy

1. **Start with your key variables** as search terms
2. Use **Boolean operators**: AND, OR, NOT
3. Use **quotation marks** for exact phrases
4. **Filter** by date, peer-reviewed, English language

**Example:** If your topic is word concreteness and memory:

"concrete words" AND "abstract words" AND recall

"word concreteness" AND memory AND "free recall"



# What to Look For

- **Peer-reviewed journal articles** — the gold standard
- **Recent papers** (last 10–15 years)
- **Highly cited classic papers** — foundational work everyone references
- **Review articles** — for broad overviews

**A single key paper that closely matches your topic is more valuable than three vaguely related ones.**

# Reading Strategically

You do NOT need to read every paper word-for-word:

1. **Abstract** — Is it relevant? What did they find?
2. **Introduction** — What's the argument? What other papers do they cite?
3. **Method** — Similar design to yours?
4. **Results** — Key findings and effect sizes
5. **Discussion** — Implications and limitations



# Part 4: Building Your Reference List

# Keeping Track of What You Find (~30 min)



# An Average Report Contains 3–5 Papers (or More)

Your Research Report Introduction needs to build an argument from the literature. That typically means citing **3–5 quality sources**.

Keeping track of those from the start is a good skill — don't leave it until Easter to find your references again.



## Reference Manager

Install **Zotero** (free) — it saves references directly from your browser and formats them automatically.

# For Each Paper, Record

1. **Full reference** (authors, year, title, journal)
2. **What they studied** (research question)
3. **How** (design, participants, key methods)
4. **What they found** (key results, effect sizes)
5. **Why it matters** for your project

# How Many Sources?

For your Research Report Introduction:

- **3–5 quality sources** is a fair target
- Mix of **classic and recent** papers
- **Quality over quantity** — 3 well-integrated sources beat 10 listed without connection





# Part 5: Developing Your Hypothesis

# From Literature to Prediction (~20 min)

# Group Discussion

## Discuss with your group:

1. What does the literature suggest will happen?
2. What direction do you predict?
3. Is your hypothesis **one-tailed** (directional) or **two-tailed**?
4. What **theory** supports your prediction?

# A Good Hypothesis

A hypothesis should be:

- **Specific** — names the IV, DV, and predicted direction
- **Testable** — can be confirmed or disconfirmed with data
- **Grounded** — based on previous research, not just a guess

“Participants will recall significantly more concrete words than abstract words in a free recall task.”





# Wrap-Up

# Before You Leave

## Checklist

- ☐ Formed a group and [registered it](#)
- ☐ Chosen your project topic (from list or your own)
- ☐ Found or identified a key paper to anchor your project
- ☐ Exchanged contact details and set up a group chat
- ☐ Looked at the [template documents](#) on Learn



# Key Dates — Don't Forget

| When                                | What                                  |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>Tomorrow</b> Fri 27 Feb, 12 noon | Research Plan due via Learn           |
| <b>Week 17</b> Thu 5 Mar            | Group: finalise methodology           |
| <b>Week 18</b> Wed 11 Mar           | <b>MCQ Exam</b> (~1 hour, in lecture) |
| <b>Week 19</b> Fri 20 Mar, 12 noon  | <b>EDS Assignment</b> due (~1 hour)   |
| <b>Week 19</b> Thu 19 Mar           | Group: <b>collect data</b>            |
| <b>Week 20</b> Thu 26 Mar           | Write-up support                      |



# Questions?

**Then let's form groups and choose topics!**